powers and establishing new equations with intra-regional ones will shape an emerging architecture. The focus must be on getting understandings in place with multiple partners, so that a more diverse balance emerges. It is especially important to reassure ASEAN about its place in the Indo-Pacific, as that grouping has driven all serious regional discussions in the past. Both literally and conceptually, this is an opportunity to enhance its centrality.

If there is a definitive articulation of India's Indo-Pacific approach, that could be in Prime Minister Modi's address to the Shangri-La Dialogue in Singapore in 2018. Its vision was of a free, open and inclusive region that had South-East Asia – which connected the two oceans – at its centre. This was underpinned by a belief in a common rules-based order that applied to all states individually as well as to the global commons. This meant that all nations have equal access as a right under international law to the use of common spaces on sea and in air. Freedom of navigation, unimpeded commerce and peaceful settlement of disputes are also to be guaranteed. The economic component of the vision was of a level-playing field for all while connectivity underlined the importance of trust and respect for sovereignty, transparency, viability and sustainability. In essence, this was a call for an Asia of cooperation, rather than of rivalry.

The future of the Indo-Pacific lies in a complex range of forces interacting on a continuous basis. As with so many other facets of international relations today, this too has many open questions. For India, it will be an important element of its relationship with China and its partnership with the West. New possibilities could be opened up with Russia, whose maritime interests may grow with the viability of Arctic commerce. The importance of the Indo-Pacific to ties with Japan, ASEAN and Australia clearly cannot be underestimated.

The sea may have determined global politics two centuries ago and then receded in its salience. Perhaps we overstated its diminution as a factor in transforming world affairs, especially when a global power arrives on the stage. There are strategies at work, some obvious and others less so. The point of agreement is the criticality of a theatre that is re-emerging through the fusion of its predecessors. It is natural that a new discourse accompanies the changes in global order. Western terminology has long been on the